Mujahideen, claiming affiliation with Al Qaeda. Convinced that they had cornered Umar, they posted the "You can run but you can't hide!" taunt on X. What they didn't anticipate was that Umar had already loaded his i20 with explosives and would execute a fidayeen attack near the crowded Red Fort area.

Pakistan's New Gameplan

With the case now handed over to the National Investigation Agency (NIA), investigators have begun to sift through mountains of intelligence records and CCTV footage to determine how the terror doctors hatched the conspiracy and to find proof of Pakistan's involvement in the attack. Counter-terror experts are convinced that Pakistan has adopted a new strategy of recruiting professionals, especially doctors in the Valley, to carry out strikes on Indian soil. This is in sharp contrast to the spectacular attacks, like the one in Pahalgam, carried out by highly-trained Pakistan-based terrorists sent out by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) agency.

This change may have come about after Pahalgam and Op Sindoor, to help Pakistan achieve the aim of plausible deniability. By employing homegrown terrorists, and educated professionals at that, to execute terror strikes, Pakistan wants to demonstrate how Kashmiris in general are disgruntled with the way the Indian state is handling affairs in the Valley. As Colonel Vivek Chadha (retd), a counter-terrorism expert and senior fellow at the Manohar Parrikar Institute of Defence Studies and Analyses (MP-IDSA), points out, "By picking highly qualified professionals like doctors, who are unlikely to be suspected of undertaking tasks of this kind, and instead of targeting Kashmir, as in the past, choosing to attack a symbol of Indian power like the Red Fort, Pakistan has employed a unique combination to gain both psychological advantage and a narrative that helps them internationally to deter India from resorting to punitive action as it did with Op Sindoor."

Other experts like R.R. Swain, former director general of J&K Police, agree that the most striking feature of the current module is the use of professionals. This has raised the threshold level to a new high, especially, as he points out, they were rarely used in the past to carry out suicide bombings. "People with higher and professional education from well-to-do families getting into bombs and bullets only vindicates the understanding that it is not an unemployment and poverty issue but indoctrination and propaganda," says Swain.

Umar, Ganai and Rather, the key members of the Faridabad module, are prime examples of such radicalisation. Umar, a native of Koil village in Pulwama, completed his MBBS and MD from GMC, Srinagar, and worked at the city's premier Shri Maharaja Hari Singh (SMHS) hospital and GMC, Anantnag,


AP

LEFT WITH THE PAIN
Grieving relatives of a blast victim at a hospital mortuary; right, Union home minister Amit Shah at the explosion spot, Nov. 10

before moving to work at Al-Falah. "He was an inspiration for the whole area. We struggled to make him a doctor," Umar's sister-in-law Muzamil said. J&K Police say that among the doctors in the module, Umar was a first among equals because of his charisma and commitment to radical Islamisation. But he was also known to be impulsive and prone to angry outbursts. Ganai, who like Umar was from Koil village, did his MBBS from Acharya Shri Chander College of Medical Sciences and Hospital in Jammu and, again like Umar, practised in Kashmir's hospitals before coming to Al-Falah. Back home, he was known to be a brilliant, industrious student. "Neither police nor army ever entered our house," Ganai's younger brother Azad said. "We are Indians and law-abiding citizens, Muzammil always focused on studies and nothing else." Qazigund resident Rather came from a modest family background; his father, now retired, was a tehsildar. He did his MBBS and MD from GMC, Anantnag, where he got to know Umar. He worked as a resident till October 2024 before shifting to the Saharanpur hospital.

THE USE OF PROFESSIONALS HAS RAISED THE THRESHOLD LEVEL TO A NEW HIGH, ESPECIALLY AS THEY WERE RARELY USED IN THE PAST TO CARRY OUT SUICIDE BOMBINGS

The Modus Operandi of Radicalisation

How did Pakistan manage to radicalise doctors in the Valley to carry out fidayeen attacks? During the course of their investigation, J&K Police learnt how two Telegram channels became the core of the radicalisation network—the first, run by Farzandan-e-Darul Uloom (Deoband), and the second operated by Umar bin Khattab, a Pakistan-based JeM terrorist. Both Umar and Maulvi Irfan were